

JUNE 2026

KHANATURAL

Rooted in Realness

ISSUE 06



Helen
Desbois

All things Ireland and Soul

Editor's Note

As the Editor-in-Chief of KhaNatural Magazine, my journey has been one of remarkable growth.

Each issue has offered me the privilege of engaging with powerful stories and inspiring individuals who are shaping the health and wellness space.

These interactions have expanded my perspective and deepened my commitment to the work we do. Through Khanatural Magazine, we get to see the world and experience the unknown.

It's my hope that you, our readers, walk away from each issue feeling just as enriched, if not more. May the insights you discover within these pages inspire choices that nurture your well-being.

Enjoy our June issue, and may your health and wellness choices keep you evolving.

Khabonina Q
Editor-in-Chief



In this issue

Helen Desbois takes us on her Ireland experience. We discover what her relocation did to her body mind and soul.

Ayanda Tetyana has a consent driven conversation with a mother of two.

"Why do you fear emotional relocation?" is a burning question by Dambisa Maqoga; and finally, what happens when the script ends? We explore these and more in this issue.

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An Audience With HELEN DESBOIS

BY KHABONINA QUBEKA

Photography by Xavier Saer

British-born, South African-raised broadcaster, actress, radio presenter and podcaster Helen Desbois has built a dynamic multi-platform career spanning radio, television, music, live performance and voice artistry.

Since relocating to Dublin in 2019, she has become one of the most recognisable voices on Irish radio while continuing to connect with fans across entertainment and media in Ireland and internationally.

With more than three decades in the entertainment industry, Desbois' first established herself in South Africa as an actress and recording artist before successfully reinventing her career in Ireland.

Shortly after moving to Dublin, her on-air instincts quickly took shape through Dublin City FM's breakfast programme, LiveDrive Breakfast heard weekday mornings across the capital.

Her warm on-air style, entertainment expertise and ability to connect with audiences have made her a popular figure in Dublin broadcasting.

She also hosts the weekend dance show Club Classics, celebrating iconic club anthems and contemporary dance music. Helen is also the Business Development Manager and Head of Training for Dublin City FM.

Desbois' broadcasting credentials were already well established before arriving in Ireland.

During her South African radio career she received multiple industry nominations and won the prestigious MTN Radio Award for Best Daytime Presenter, along with a Liberty Radio Award for Best Newsreader.

She also received a Woman of the Year in Media honour and an Artes Legends Award recognising her contribution to the arts and entertainment industry.



X KHANATURAL

Photography by Xavier Saer



HELEN'S JOURNEY

Not only have you had the most wonderful career, but you are a woman of many talents, mastering them all. How do you keep yourself mentally healthy and balanced?

I think balance is something I constantly work on, rather than something I've fully realised. My career has taken me through so many different roles over the years, with radio, music, acting and presenting, and even being a Mum, and each one comes with its own pressures and rewards. What keeps me grounded is staying connected to real life outside of work. Family, good friends, quiet time at home and a lot of laughter are really important to me. I've also learned that protecting my peace is paramount. Resting, setting boundaries and taking time away from noise are just as important as being ambitious.

You have always been in incredible shape. Is it genetic or is there a routine you've followed basically all your life?

Oh my goodness, thank you for that! It's probably a mix of both, I guess. I've always believed more in consistency than in extremes. I'm not someone who follows intense fad diets or crazy routines. I try to stay active, drink lots of water and listen to my body and like everyone, I haven't always got it right, but that's life. Balance is key and I also think stress and happiness show physically, so when you feel good mentally, it reflects in all areas of your life and outlook.

The last time I saw you was before you left for Dublin, in 2019. I had just given birth to my daughter, who is now 7. We grabbed a quick bite at Woolies, you handed me a little gift for my child and you were off. How long did it take you to acclimatise to Dublin and were you homesick at all?

I can't believe that it's been 7 years since I left, I still miss you and everyone so much! I was definitely very homesick in the beginning, that's for sure, but I believe you need to be present where you are. Ten days after arriving in Ireland, I booked a Blogger's Brunch event online and met my tribe, who welcomed me, loved me and have supported my journey all these years; add the extra challenge of Covid times and it was a massive life lesson, to be sure! My life is completely different than I ever could have imagined, and I have faced major changes and challenges too.

I have dealt with the sudden loss of my dear mama and a divorce thrown into the mix too. At the end of the day, I guess it's about reinvention, hope, humility and love - and I also get to do a job I love, presenting the breakfast show on Dublin City FM; thank goodness I'm a morning person. I really am a lucky girl, I have cheerleaders and supporters back in South Africa and also many new ones here on this beautiful island, I now call home!



A Desbois Heart

Beyond your talents, the one thing that makes you unforgettable is your heart. I knew you'd make it anywhere in the world due to your passion and kindness and love for life. Would you say this is something the world is missing? Are we so focused on "position" and "labels" that we are forgetting what matters most: the human element and the heart?

Wow, thank you for saying that. Oh, for sure. I think people are so focused on titles, status, followers and labels that sometimes we forget the basics like kindness, empathy and genuine connection.

The older I get, the more I realise that it really comes down to authenticity, values and kindness. Talent can open doors, but good character is what keeps them open.

The world feels very transactional these days, and I guess it is difficult to open our hearts and trust, not to mention, maintain a positive attitude all the time.

Finally, how often do you come down to SA ? And whats next for this unlimited star of ours?

I have only been back to visit twice now, but definitely need to make a plan to come across next year to see my darling dad and step mama and all my friends.

Thank goodness for social media; it really does make the world seem a little smaller and help keep us connected to our special people.

As for the future, more hustle for me and a world of adventure, opportunity and possibly more reinvention.

I'm up for it all.

Skin ...

KHA HONEY

2026



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Seamoss in Ireland

According to Helen Desbois

BY KHABONINA QUBEKA

I got super excited when I realised just where Helen is in the world and how it aligns with the KhaNatural business: Irish sea moss.

I asked her if she knew the history and whether she eats it fresh on a daily basis.

"Irish Sea moss is amazing! You have to take a trip up the Wild Atlantic Way sometime and see where it comes from. There are some of the most stunning stretches of coastline and gorgeous little towns and villages to see.

I have tried various versions of the sea moss products and love them! My favourite has to be the gel from Sea Moss Sublime, they also do gummies which are handy. I know you can also get the dehydrated sea moss to cook with, I must try that. However, when I'm home, it's KhaNatural sea moss all the way."

HEALING JOURNAL



A mother reflects on how boys and girls are shaped differently in the same home, and how those differences later collide in adulthood.

BY AYANDA TETYANA

Behavioural Science Consultant



Consent Conditioning...

... and the Different Worlds Boys and Girls Inherit

As a mother, I have been reflecting on how boys and girls are shaped differently in the same home, and how those differences I am learning the world does not treat them the same once they leave it.

I am raising a son and a daughter in the same South African home, under the same roof and love. I see it in what I find myself teaching my daughter without always meaning to:

- watch your drink.
- Trust your instincts.
- Don't ignore discomfort.
- Leave when something feels wrong.

These are not formal lessons. They surface in passing: in the way I read a room before she does, in the stories I choose to tell, and in the ones I cannot fully bring myself to say out loud.

And I see it in my son too, but in a different language:

- be confident.
- Be strong.
- Don't shrink yourself.
- Go after what you want.

These are also important lessons, given with love. But I begin to notice what the world adds to them once he steps outside the home. His persistence is often read as confidence. Pressure is softened into charm. Permission is assumed, even when it is not clearly agreed.

In social science, this is often called differential socialization. It is the way boys and girls are shaped into different emotional and behavioural systems, not by design, but through repetition, culture, and what is rewarded around them.

My daughter learns to read atmosphere. Before explanation, there is safety. Before permission, there is caution. Safety before politeness. Over time, this becomes instinct. Before touch, she learns not only what to feel, but whether she is allowed to move away without creating tension.

She learns to consider not only what she feels, but how that feeling will be received.

- How to say no without escalation?
- How to move away without creating tension.
- How to weigh her comfort against the social consequences of expressing it.

She learns to consider not only what she feels, but how that feeling will be received. How to say no without escalation? How to move away without creating tension. How to weigh her comfort against the social consequences of expressing it.

When she does speak, she is not always met with clarity. Sometimes she is questioned. Sometimes she is told she misunderstood. Sometimes she is encouraged to soften what she already knows she felt clearly. So she learns a quieter skill: how to protect herself while also managing other people's reactions to her discomfort.

My son learns something different. He learns to trust intention. To assume clarity unless something is directly refused. To measure himself more by what he meant than what another person experienced. Not because he is careless, but because this is what his environment reinforces as normal movement through the world.

And this is where the gap begins.



When these two systems meet later in life, they do not always translate. One person is communicating through silence, hesitation, and withdrawal.

The other is responding through persistence and forward motion. One is trying to prevent escalation.

The other is often trying to maintain momentum. And in that mismatch, a line can be crossed without both people experiencing the moment in the same way.

This is how many moments are later described differently. Not always because of intention, but because impact and interpretation were never speaking the same language.

And then there is something harder to sit with the longer I watch this pattern. When a woman says something felt wrong, the first response is often not curiosity. It is correction. Or defence. Or doubt.

Sometimes it is not only men who respond this way. Sometimes other women hesitate to fully sit with what is being said. Not because they do not care, but because accepting her experience would disrupt something else they are holding onto. A relationship. A reputation. A familiar version of someone they thought they knew. So the focus shifts away from her experience and toward explanation, character, or interpretation.

And slowly, what she felt in her own body becomes the least stable truth in the room. Because beneath all the argument and interpretation, there is still something simpler trying to be heard.

That she is saying: this is how it felt for me. And if even that requires negotiation before it is believed, then what is being protected is not truth. It is comfort. And comfort has never been a reliable measure of safety.



So I find myself returning to my children. To my son and my brother, I do not ask for perfection. I ask for something harder. That they become willing to sit with discomfort long enough to notice what they were not taught to see. That they resist the easy comfort of assuming that good intention is enough to close the gap. That they understand that there will be moments where nothing looks like harm from their side, but something has still shifted in the other person.

And that maturity begins at the point where they are willing to care more about what someone else is communicating than about explaining themselves. This is where many men are never asked to go further.

They are not required to stay long enough in someone else's experience to feel what it is like to live there. I am a mother raising a son and a daughter.



And to my daughter and my sister, I do not ask you to shrink yourselves for understanding. I ask them to trust what they know, even when it is inconvenient for others to accept. Even when it is explained away. Even when it is softened into something more comfortable for the people around them. Because what she feels is not a debate. It is information.

And perhaps the most difficult truth in all of this is that understanding does not only require empathy. It requires interruption. The willingness, especially from men, to pause the defence of themselves long enough to ask what is happening for the other person right now, not only what is happening in their own intention.

That is where accountability begins. Not in explanation. In restraint. In attention. In the uncomfortable act of not moving forward just because nothing has said "stop" loudly enough yet.

JUNE 2026



BEARD

KHANATURAL SHOP

Why You Love Our Beard Oil

Our Beard oil is like a drink of water for your facial hair - it hydrates, softens and keeps your beard looking its best. It is a blend of carrier oils and essential oils that moisturize both your beard hair and the skin underneath, tackling issues like dryness, itchiness, and beard dandruff.



WHY YOU FEAR EMOTIONAL RELOCATION

Emotional Relocation Is
Nothing To Be Feared



BY DAMBISA MAQOGA

We often become accustomed to believing that what we present to the world, or what we offer emotionally, cannot be modified.

We convince ourselves that this is just who we are, that this is how we respond, how we cope, how we love and how we survive.

But the truth is, our emotional responses are not always fixed. They are often learned, shaped and adjusted over time.

In my life, I have over 20 close friends and family members, as well as a lover, and through these different relationships,

I have learned that we all deal with emotions differently. How I show up with one person is not always how I show up with another. How I treat myself in one situation is not always how I treat myself in the next.

These experiences have made me realise that, to some extent, we are capable of shaping how we respond to things, people and feelings.

By definition, emotional relocation is the psychological process of adjusting to a major move. Beyond the literal meaning, it can also speak to the internal movement we experience when life demands that we shift emotionally.

It is the process of moving from one emotional state to another. From fear to acceptance. From resistance to awareness. From pain to understanding. From survival to self-regulation.

When we think about emotional relocation in this way, it becomes clear why many people fear it. We fear what it may bring. We fear who we may become. We fear what we may have to release. We fear whether we will still recognise ourselves once we have changed.

But emotional relocation is nothing to be feared.

Every situation we have encountered has, in some way, taught us how to respond, adapt and move forward.

Even the difficult moments have propelled us to handle life head-on.

They have shown us that we are not as emotionally helpless as we sometimes believe ourselves to be.



Now, more than ever, we need to become aware of our emotional movements.

The way we move emotionally can either build us or break us. It can keep us stuck in old patterns, or it can help us become more honest, more grounded and more intentional about who we are becoming.

Emotional relocation does not mean abandoning yourself. It means paying attention to where you are emotionally, recognising when a place no longer serves you, and allowing yourself to move.

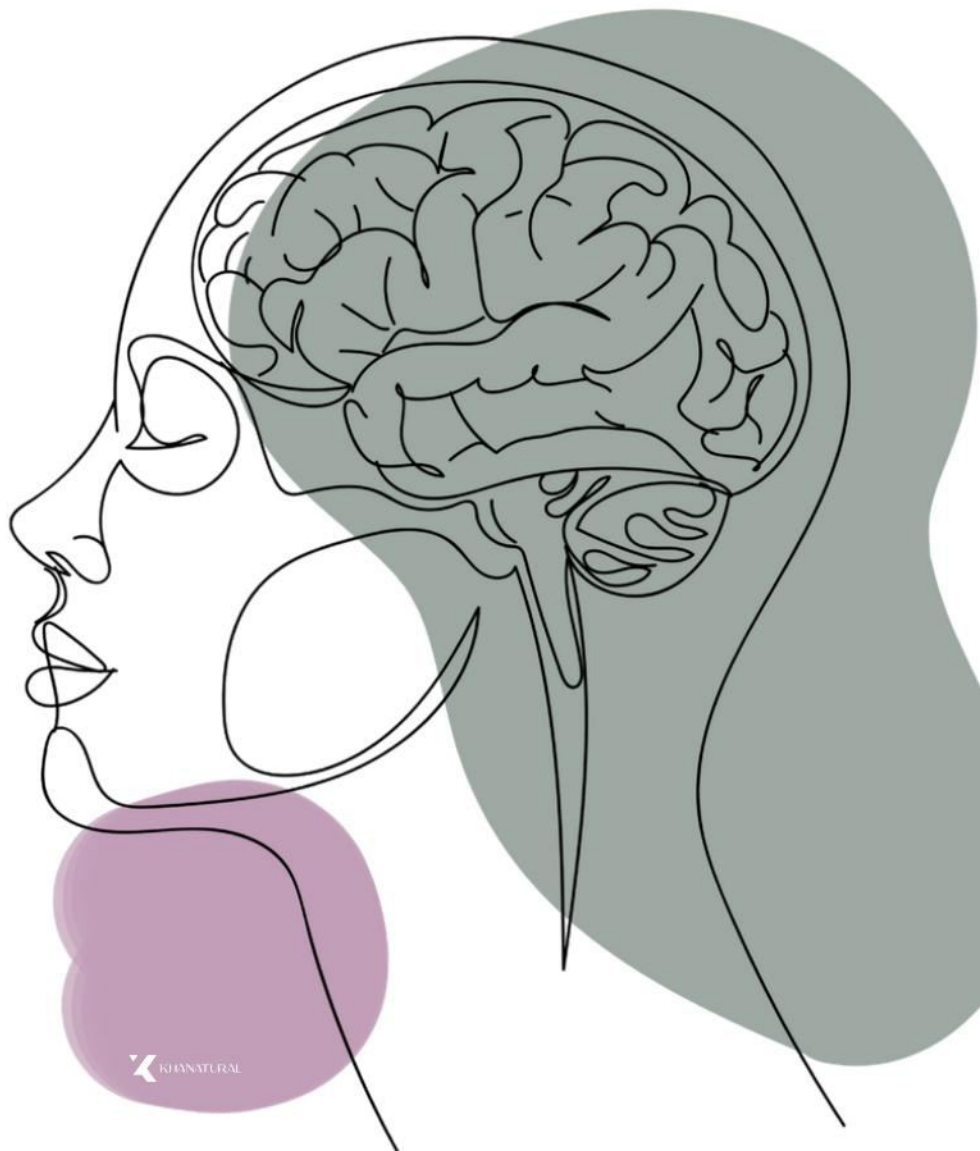
There is nothing to fear in becoming more aware of yourself.

There is nothing to fear in learning new ways to respond.

There is nothing to fear in realising that you are capable of change.

Sometimes, the greatest move you will ever make is not physical.

It is emotional. It is the decision to stop living in fear of your own growth.



The Apology Men Struggle to Give

BY MOKWADI WA MOMPEDI

There are words many men find harder to say than “I love you.”

“I was wrong.”
“I’m sorry.”

Not the quick, convenient apology that ends a conversation. Not the half-hearted, ‘if I hurt you’ version that avoids responsibility. But the real one. The kind that requires a man to stand still, look at the damage he has caused, and own it without defence.

That apology is rare.

We Were Not Taught How
Most men were not raised in environments where accountability was modeled with grace.

We saw anger.
We saw silence.
We saw authority.

But we rarely saw a man sit down and say, “I made a mistake, and I am sorry for how it affected you.”

So we grow up associating apology with weakness. With losing control. With surrendering power. And when the moment comes — when we’ve hurt someone we care about — our instinct is not to lean in. It’s to protect ourselves.

We explain.
We justify.
We minimise.
Anything but apologise properly.

Pride Speaks Louder Than Truth

Pride has a quiet way of convincing a man that he is right, even when he knows he isn’t.

It tells him that admitting fault will make him smaller.
That saying sorry will shift the balance.
That holding his ground is strength.

But pride is not strength; It’s distance.

It creates space between a man and the people who love him - and over time, that space becomes silence.

What a Real Apology Looks Like

A real apology is simple, but not easy.

It sounds like:
“I hurt you. I see it. And I’m sorry.”

No conditions.
No explanations that shift blame.
No expectation of immediate forgiveness.

It requires presence.
It requires listening — not to respond, but to understand.

And sometimes, it requires accepting that the apology may not fix everything. That the damage may take time to heal. That trust, once broken, is rebuilt slowly.

Accountability Is Strength
The strongest men are not the ones who never get it wrong. They are the ones who take responsibility when they do.



Because accountability builds trust.
It deepens relationships.
It creates safety — the kind that allows
people to be honest without fear.

A man who can apologise properly is not
losing power.
He is showing control over his ego.

And that is a different kind of strength.

Maybe the apology we struggle to give
is not about the other person.
Maybe it's about the version of ourselves
we are afraid to confront.

But growth begins there — in that
uncomfortable moment where truth
matters more than pride.

So when the time comes, don't rush it.
Don't avoid it.

Stand in it.
Own it.
Say it properly.

Because sometimes, the most powerful
thing a man can say... is "I'm sorry."



Mokwadi is a writer, business strategist, and lawyer by training. He is passionate about the intersection of African identity, wellness, and digital storytelling. When he's not helping creatives build impactful brands, he's writing stories that challenge the status quo and inspire new ways of thinking.



From Jozi to Dublin Through Food

with
HELEN
DESBOIS





Helen continues to mesmerise us with her new life in Dublin.

We were very curious about how her diet compares with the South African food she knows so well.

Here she shares more about her diet and food culture in Ireland.

I keep it tidy during the week with a protein rich start of yoghurt, chia and flax seeds and fruit. Lunch is normally some tuna or mackerel with sourdough, and dinner is a varied affair of dishes, mostly dependent on what my lad fancies.

Food is definitely one of my love languages, so I love feeding him! One thing I noticed about the food here is that the Irish are proud of their produce, and it is really good that I have made it my mission to master and cook some real Irish dishes, too. Beef and Guinness Stew, which I have yet to properly master, Colcannon- comprised of yummy, mashed potato with kale, butter and milk- and one of my firm favourites, Seafood Chowder!

The foodie scene is off the charts in Dublin and that there is so much choice and good food on offer. Sampling new spots and delicacies also adds to the experience. But I must say, a good Irish pub lunch has a place in my heart.

The tea scene in Dublin, and the braai culture, are very different to South Africa. I am, however, bringing and sharing the braai gear with as many people as I can.



When The Script Ends...

Are creatives too emotionally connected?

BY KHABONINA Q

South Africa's entertainment and creative industry has been particularly loud in recent weeks.

I am familiar with that sound. I have been in the industry for years, and I have found that we can become emotionally connected quickly. The anxiety often comes from knowing that the connection is temporary. I sometimes question whether the intimacy is real, or whether it is mimicking the "product story" that has temporarily brought us together.

Analysts say: The reality is that film sets create conditions for intense emotional bonding: long hours, vulnerability, creative collaboration, physical proximity, unpredictable timelines and emotional scenes can push performers into situations where attachment, emotional entanglement or abuse of power may develop if boundaries are not maintained.

"Why do creative professionals become so emotionally connected, and what role does wellness play in maintaining healthy boundaries?"

The film industry is often viewed as glamorous, exciting and creatively fulfilling, yet behind the lights, cameras and red carpets lies an environment that can be emotionally intense and psychologically demanding.

Actors, writers, directors and crew members work in close, collaborative spaces, often spending long days together and sharing vulnerable moments and creative experiences that can forge emotional bonds.

Many people have wondered why relationships in the film industry seem to form so quickly. Why do colleagues become attached to one another? Why do romantic relationships often emerge on set?

And why have conversations around harassment, power dynamics, and the #MeToo movement become so important within the entertainment world?



"Perhaps the real wellness challenge in the entertainment industry is not avoiding connection, but learning how to connect deeply while maintaining healthy boundaries."

The answer may lie in the unique emotional landscape of creative work.

Film production requires a level of vulnerability that few professions demand. Actors may portray intimate scenes, writers share personal stories, directors guide emotional performances, and producers manage the pressure of bringing a vision to life.

Everyone becomes invested in a shared goal. In this environment, colleagues often witness one another at their most authentic, exhausted, passionate, and emotionally exposed.

Psychologists have long understood that intense shared experiences can accelerate feelings of trust and connection.

Long working hours, high-pressure situations, and a common purpose can create a sense of closeness that feels deeper than ordinary workplace relationships.

What some describe as a "spiritual connection" may actually be the result of emotional intimacy formed through shared experiences and vulnerability.

Emotional closeness is not the same as emotional health. Without strong boundaries, these connections become complicated; professional admiration can be mistaken for romantic attraction, and dependence on colleagues for emotional support can blur personal and professional lines.

This is why wellness must become a central conversation within the entertainment industry.

Wellness is not only about physical fitness or mental health practices. It is also about emotional awareness, healthy boundaries, self-respect, and understanding the difference between genuine connection and emotional dependency.

Professionals who prioritise wellness are often better equipped to navigate the intense relationships that naturally develop in creative spaces.

Creating a healthier industry requires more than policies and regulations. It requires a culture that values emotional intelligence, respect, and accountability. It requires individuals who can recognize when a connection is healthy and when it may be crossing professional boundaries.

The film industry will always be a place where stories are told, emotions are explored, and human connection is celebrated. The challenge is ensuring that those connections are grounded in wellness, integrity, and mutual respect.

When the script ends and the cameras stop rolling, the most important role any professional can play is that of a healthy, self-aware human being.

Perhaps the real wellness challenge in the entertainment industry is not avoiding connection, but learning how to connect deeply while maintaining healthy boundaries.



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